



Ramadan 101

Guide for Reverts



About this guide

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Ramadan is a time of renewal, reflection, and reconnection—with Allah, our faith, and the legacy of the Prophet ﷺ. Whether you are a revert experiencing your first Ramadan, someone revisiting the foundational concepts, or simply looking to deepen your understanding, this guide is here to support you.

Our community is built on love for the Prophet ﷺ and the wisdom he left for us. We are inspired by the teachings of prominent scholars in the West, such as Shaykh Hamza Yusuf, Shaykh Yahya Rhodus, and Imam Omar Suleiman, who remind us that Islam is not just a set of practices but a path to inner transformation.

This guide is not a scholarly work—rather, it is a sincere effort to share what we know to be true. If you ever feel unsure or want to expand your knowledge, we encourage you to consult with an imam, seek guidance from the Qur'an and hadith, and continue learning from the vast tradition of Islamic scholarship.

May this Ramadan be a source of spiritual growth, abundant barakah, and a means of drawing closer to Allah. O Allah, grant us sincerity in our worship, strength in our fasting, and acceptance of our prayers. Fill our hearts with light, our actions with righteousness, and our lives with Your mercy.

Ameen.

Sincerely,
The Daily Sunnah

Let's start with the basics!

02

What is Ramadan?

Ramadan (رمضان) is the ninth month of the Islamic lunar calendar. It is the holiest month for Muslims because it commemorates the revelation of the Quran to Prophet Muhammad (SAW) through Angel Jibreel (Gabriel).

“The month of Ramadan [is that] in which was revealed the Quran, a guidance for the people and clear proofs of guidance and criterion...” (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:185)

How is the month determined?

Ramadan begins and ends based on the sighting of the crescent moon, following the Islamic lunar calendar.

This means it lasts 29 or 30 days, depending on the moon phases. The Islamic lunar year is shorter than the solar year by about 10–12 days, so Ramadan shifts earlier each year, cycling through all seasons over a 33-year period.



Fasting During Ramadan

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Fasting in Ramadan is a core act of worship for Muslims and serves as a spiritual, physical, and communal practice.

What is Fasting? Fasting (Sawm) is the act of abstaining from:

- Food and drink (including water).
- Sexual relations. Negative behaviours such as lying, gossiping, or arguing.

What is the purpose of fasting?

01

Spiritual Development

Fasting is an act of devotion to Allah, teaching taqwa (God-consciousness).

- "...that you may become righteous." (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:183)

02

Self-Discipline and Patience

Fasting cultivates self-control, patience, and the ability to resist temptations.

03

Empathy and Gratitude

It allows Muslims to experience hunger, fostering empathy for the less fortunate and gratitude for blessings.

04

Cleansing of Sins

Fasting is an opportunity for spiritual renewal and forgiveness: Prophet Muhammad (SAW) said: "Whoever fasts during Ramadan with faith and seeking reward, his past sins will be forgiven." (Bukhari and Muslim)

Not everyone has to fast!

Certain groups are not required to fast, reflecting Islam's emphasis on **ease** and **compassion**:

- Sick or those with chronic illnesses.
- Travelers (with the condition to make up missed fasts later).
- Pregnant or nursing women if fasting might harm them or their child.
- Children (before reaching puberty). Elderly who cannot fast due to weakness.

Missed fasts can be compensated by:

- Making up the days later.
- Fidya: Feeding a poor person for each missed day if fasting is impossible.

Allah (SWT) is the most forgiving, so do not fear if you miss a fast or must break one. He knows your intentions in your heart.

Fasting for Women

For women who menstruate, you are exempt from fasting during these days.

You can make up for the missed days after Ramadan is over. Although you cannot pray at this time, you should still take the opportunity to deepen your faith. Listen to Muslim podcasts, perform charitable acts, or memorize duas.

Allah has blessed you with this break, so do not waste it!

The Daily Routine

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There are three aspects to the day in Ramadan.
Each phase is important and comes with both
blessings and challenges.



Suhoor/Sehri (Before the fast) A meal is eaten before Fajr to prepare for the fast.

It is considered a blessing, and the Prophet Muhammad (SAW) encouraged it: "Take Suhoor, for there is a blessing in it."
(Bukhari and Muslim)



Fasting Hours During fasting, Muslims refrain from all prohibited actions and focus on acts of worship such as prayer, Quran recitation, and charity. The duration of fasting varies by year and location, but it is typically for around 12 hours.



Iftar (Breaking the Fast) The fast is broken at sunset with dates and water, following the Sunnah (tradition) of the Prophet Muhammad (SAW).

The supplication for breaking the fast is:

"Allahumma inni laka sumtu, wa bika aamantu,
wa 'alayka tawakkaltu, wa 'ala rizq-ika-aftartu."

(O Allah, I fasted for You, and I believe in You, and I put
my trust in You, and with Your sustenance, I break my
fast.)

Suhoor: Why is it important?

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We begin each day with Suhoor (سحور), also referred to as Sehri. It is highly encouraged in Islam and holds both spiritual and physical importance.

Following the Sunnah

Eating Suhoor is a tradition of Prophet Muhammad (SAW).

He said: "Take Suhoor, for there is a blessing in it." (Bukhari and Muslim)

Earning Rewards

Even if it's just a sip of water or a small morsel, having Suhoor earns blessings and fulfills a Sunnah act. If you eat suhoor with the intention of obeying the command of Prophet Muhammad (SAW) and following his example, then your suhoor is an act of worship and you will be rewarded for it accordingly

A Time for Dua and Worship

(Suhoor time falls in the last part of the night, a time when Allah is closest to His servants:

- "Our Lord descends every night to the lowest heaven when one-third of the night remains, and says: 'Who is calling upon Me so I may answer him? Who is asking Me so I may give him? Who is seeking My forgiveness so I may forgive him?'" (Bukhari and Muslim).

Energy for the Day

Suhoor provides the body with essential nutrients to sustain energy and focus during the long fasting hours. Skipping Suhoor can lead to fatigue and difficulty concentrating.

Preventing Dehydration

Drinking water or hydrating foods during Suhoor helps avoid dehydration, especially in hot climates or long fasting hours.

Stabilizing Blood Sugar

A balanced Suhoor keeps blood sugar levels stable, reducing fatigue and hunger.

Suhoor: Tips & Tricks

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Suhoor comes very early, and it's tempting to skip it! However, with these tips you will see the benefits of Suhoor and ultimately look forward to each morning.

Eat a balanced meal

Prioritize foods that release energy slowly to keep you full longer:

- Complex Carbs: Whole grains (oats, brown rice, whole wheat bread).
- Protein: Eggs, yogurt, cheese, beans, or nuts.
- Healthy Fats: Avocado, olive oil, or nuts/seeds.
- Avoid sugary foods and refined carbs (like pastries), which cause energy crashes.

Choose quick and easy recipes....

Nobody wants to be spending an hour getting breakfast ready. Some easy ideas are:

- Smoothies: Blend yogurt, fruits, oats, and nuts for a quick meal.
- Dates with Milk: A simple, Sunnah-inspired option.
- Nut Butter Toast: Whole-grain toast with peanut or almond butter.
- Cereal: Find a high fibre, low sugar option. Add bananas for extra nutrients

...or meal prep!

You can also prep and freeze breakfast meals ahead of time, so you just have to heat them up in the morning. Some good options:

- Breakfast burritos: Combine egg, hash brown, cheese, and halal bacon for a tasty breakfast wrap
- Overnight Oats: Add chia seeds and nuts for extra fibre
- Egg Muffins: Add whatever leftovers you have (veggies, chicken)

Stay hydrated (fruits are a great way to do this)

Drink plenty of water during Suhoor to avoid thirst during the day. Include hydrating foods like cucumbers, watermelon, or oranges. Avoid caffeine (coffee, tea, sodas) as it can dehydrate you.

And stay away from oily/salty food (these will make you feel sluggish).

Fasting: Tips and Tricks

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You will feel tired, it's impossible to avoid. The first week of Ramadan, as your body adjusts to this new routine, can be particularly challenging. However, this will bring greater spiritual focus and clarity, Inshallah.

Manage Tiredness

Take Short Breaks

- If possible, take brief breaks during work to rest or stretch.
- Step away from your desk or workspace to re-energize and avoid mental fatigue.

Power Nap

- A short nap (10–20 minutes) in the afternoon can help combat tiredness and boost focus.

Get Fresh Air

- A quick walk or simply stepping outside can refresh your mind and body.

Optimize Sleep

- Ensure you get enough rest at night by sleeping early and taking advantage of post-Iftar hours for relaxation. Aim for 6–7
- hours of sleep overall, even if split into chunks.

Remember the Purpose of Ramadan

- As Muslims, we partake in Ramadan to remind ourselves of our privileges. The hunger, thirst, and tiredness we feel is only temporary. Fasting helps us practice self-discipline and deepen empathy for those less fortunate. Keeping this in mind eases the mental exhaustion.

Fasting: Tips and Tricks

Stay Productive at Work

Plan Your Day

Schedule high-focus tasks for the morning when you're most alert.

Reserve repetitive or less demanding tasks for the afternoon when energy dips.

Communicate with Colleagues

If you feel comfortable, let your colleagues or supervisor know you're fasting, so they understand if your energy levels fluctuate.

Stay Organized

Use to-do lists or productivity tools to prioritize essential tasks.

Minimize Distractions

Limit unnecessary meetings or activities to stay focused on your main responsibilities.

Avoid Energy Drains

Limit exposure to the sun or physically demanding tasks, especially in the afternoon.

Dress in light, breathable clothing to stay comfortable.

Be Kind to Yourself

Accept that fasting might slow you down slightly, and that's okay. Prioritize essential tasks and let go of non-urgent ones.

Iftar: Time to eat!

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Iftar, the meal to break the fast at sunset, is a time of gratitude and joy. It's essential to approach it mindfully to replenish your body and soul after a day of fasting.

The Sunnah Way to Break Your Fast: Start with Dates and Water

The Prophet Muhammad (SAW) broke his fast with fresh or dry dates and water. Dates provide a quick energy boost, while water helps rehydrate.

Supplication for breaking the fast

Say this dua before you break your fast:

"Allahumma inni laka sumtu,
wa bika aamantu, wa 'alayka
tawakkaltu, wa 'ala rizq-ika-
aftartu."

(O Allah, I fasted for You, and I believe in You,
and I put my trust in You, and with Your
sustenance, I break my fast.)



Take a moment to be grateful

The first sip of water or bite of food is so satisfying. However, we should remember why we are fasting in the first place. Reflect on the blessings of food and family.

Iftar: Let's make our plate

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Start Light:

After breaking your fast with dates and water, allow your body to adjust before eating a full meal. Perform Maghrib prayer during this pause.

Portion Control:

Avoid piling your plate. You will want to eat everything in front of you, but try to avoid the temptation! Overeating can cause discomfort and stomach pain. Perform Maghrib prayer after breaking your fast and before eating a full meal; this will help your stomach adjust.

Focus on Balance:

If you go to an iftar event, you will probably see many appetizers. Although delicious, these are typically fried and greasy. Try to eat them in moderation, and chew slowly. (Very basic advice, but after fasting all day all you can think about is eating as fast as you can!)

A healthy Iftar meal should include:

- Complex carbs: Brown rice, whole grains, or sweet potatoes.
- Protein: Chicken, fish, meat, and eggs.
- Vegetables: Salads or roasted veggies for fiber and nutrients.
- Healthy fats: Olive oil, avocado, or nuts.

Rehydrate:

Drink water gradually throughout the evening to rehydrate without bloating.

- Avoid sugary or carbonated drinks, which can lead to energy crashes and dehydration.
- Herbal teas or infused water (with mint, lemon, or cucumber) are good alternatives.



The Holiest Night

Laylat al-Qadr, or "The Night of Decree," is one of the holiest nights in Islam, occurring during the last ten nights of Ramadan.

Significance of Laylat al-Qadr

Reference in the Quran:

- Laylat al-Qadr is explicitly mentioned in the Quran in [Surah Al-Qadr](#) (Chapter 97):
"Indeed, We sent the Qur'an down during the Night of Decree. And what can make you know what is the Night of Decree? The Night of Decree is better than a thousand months. The angels and the Spirit descend therein by permission of their Lord for every matter. Peace it is until the emergence of dawn."(Surah Al-Qadr, 97:1-5)
- This equates worship during this single night to worship over 83 years and 4 months.

Revelation of the Quran:

Laylat al-Qadr marks the beginning of the Quran's revelation to Prophet Muhammad (SAW) through Angel Jibreel (Gabriel).

Forgiveness of Sins:

- The Prophet Muhammad (SAW) said:
"Whoever stands (in prayer) on the Night of Decree out of faith and seeking reward, his previous sins will be forgiven." (Bukhari)



The Holiest Night

When Does Laylat al-Qadr Occur?

Last Ten Nights of Ramadan:

- It is hidden within the final ten nights of Ramadan to encourage worship and devotion throughout.

Odd Nights:

- Most scholars suggest it is likely to occur on one of the odd-numbered nights: 21st, 23rd, 25th, 27th, or 29th night of Ramadan.

27th Night:

- While many consider the 27th night as highly likely, the exact date is unknown to motivate Muslims to strive in worship during all ten nights. These final ten nights are an opportunity to connect deeply with Allah (SWT).

Acts of Worship on Laylat al-Qadr

Quran Recitation:

- Spend time reading, understanding, and reflecting on the Quran.

Prayer (Salah):

- Perform voluntary prayers, including Tahajjud (night prayer).
- Prolong your sujood (prostration) and make heartfelt supplications.

Dhikr (Remembrance of Allah):

- Recite phrases like:
 - SubhanAllah (Glory be to Allah)
 - Alhamdulillah (Praise be to Allah)
 - Allahu Akbar (Allah is the Greatest)

Charity and Good Deeds:

- Giving in charity during Laylat al-Qadr multiplies the reward exponentially.

The Quran and Ramadan

Revelation of the Quran

The Quran was first revealed during Ramadan:

- "The month of Ramadan [is that] in which was revealed the Quran, a guidance for mankind and clear proofs of guidance and the criterion [between right and wrong]." (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:185)

This is the time to increase our understanding of the Quran

Ramadan is a perfect time to reinforce and deepen our understanding of the teachings of the Quran

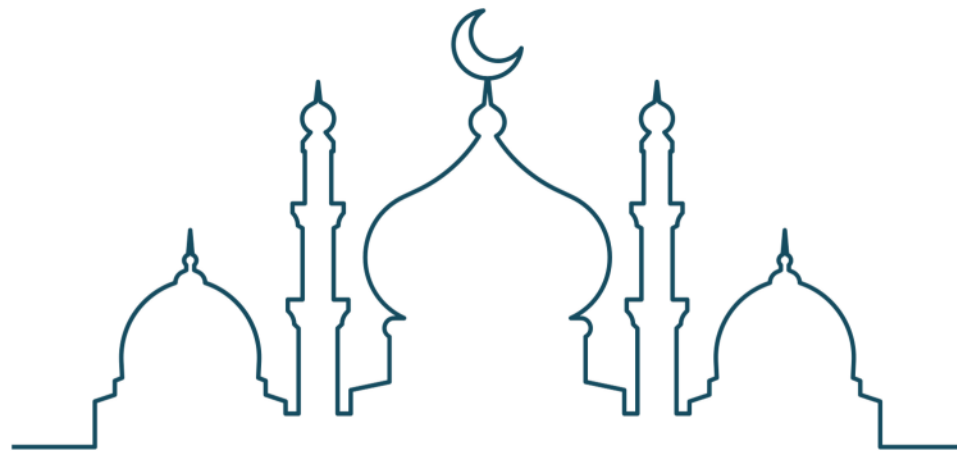
- Taraweeh prayers: Special nightly prayers during Ramadan where long portions of the Quran are recited. Many Muslims aim to complete the entire Quran during Ramadan by dividing it into daily portions (1 Juz' per day).

Quranic Guidance in Ramadan

Ramadan emphasizes the role of the Quran as a guide and a criterion for life.



- Muslims focus on reciting, understanding, and reflecting on its verses to strengthen their connection with Allah (SWT).
- The Quran provides instructions on fasting, emphasizing its purpose: "...Fasting is prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you, that you may attain Taqwa (consciousness of Allah)." (Surah Al- Baqarah, 2:183)

**30**
DAYS

Quran Tracker

DAY 1 Read Juz 1 ☐	DAY 2 Read Juz 2 ☐	DAY 3 Read Juz 3 ☐	DAY 4 Read Juz 4 ☐	DAY 5 Read Juz 5 ☐
DAY 6 Read Juz 6 ☐	DAY 7 Read Juz 7 ☐	DAY 8 Read Juz 8 ☐	DAY 9 Read Juz 9 ☐	DAY 10 Read Juz 10 ☐
DAY 11 Read Juz 11 ☐	DAY 12 Read Juz 12 ☐	DAY 13 Read Juz 13 ☐	DAY 14 Read Juz 14 ☐	DAY 15 Read Juz 15 ☐
DAY 16 Read Juz 16 ☐	DAY 17 Read Juz 17 ☐	DAY 18 Read Juz 18 ☐	DAY 19 Read Juz 19 ☐	DAY 20 Read Juz 20 ☐
DAY 21 Read Juz 21 ☐	DAY 22 Read Juz 22 ☐	DAY 23 Read Juz 23 ☐	DAY 24 Read Juz 24 ☐	DAY 25 Read Juz 25 ☐
DAY 26 Read Juz 26 ☐	DAY 27 Read Juz 27 ☐	DAY 28 Read Juz 28 ☐	DAY 29 Read Juz 29 ☐	DAY 30 Read Juz 30 ☐

Commit to your Salah

Ramadan is an ideal time to develop better prayer habits. This is individual to you: it may be reaching all five prayers in a day or increasing the number of sunnat rakats. Set a reasonable goal for yourself and strive to achieve it.

Each of the 5 prayers has a different number of rakats:

Sunnah: not mandatory, but preferable

Fardh: obligatory

Nafl: optional, gives you extra rewards

(Witr): not mandatory, but highly recommended.

Namaaz	Sunnat	Fard	Sunnat	Nafl	Vitar	Nafl
Fajr	2	2				
Dhuhr	4	4	2	2		
Asr	4	4				
Magrib		3	2	2		
Isha	4	4	2	2	3	2

Eid al-Fitr: Celebration After Ramadan

Eid al-Fitr is one of the most joyous and significant Islamic celebrations. It marks the end of Ramadan, a month of fasting, prayer, and spiritual reflection. Here's a breakdown of what Eid entails:

The Meaning and Significance of Eid al-Fitr

- **Meaning:** "Eid" means festival, and "Fitr" means breaking the fast.
- **Spiritual Significance:** It is a day of gratitude to Allah for providing the strength and guidance to complete Ramadan. It also emphasizes community, generosity, and the importance of joy in Islam

Important Rituals and Practices

- **Sighting of the Crescent Moon:** The festival begins after the new crescent moon is sighted, marking the start of the month of Shawwal.
- **Giving Zakat al-Fitr (Charity):** Muslims pay Zakat al-Fitr before the Eid prayer. This ensures that even the less fortunate can partake in the celebrations. It usually consists of staple food items or their monetary equivalent.
- **Eid Prayer (Salat al-Eid):** A special communal prayer is performed in mosques or open fields. The prayer includes a sermon (khutbah) emphasizing themes of gratitude and unity.
- **Visiting Family and Friends:** Muslims wear their best clothes, often new or specially prepared for Eid, and spend the day visiting loved ones and exchanging greetings.
- **Feasting and Sharing Food:** Families prepare elaborate meals and share them with neighbours, friends, and the needy.
- **Exchanging Gifts:** Giving gifts, especially to children, is a highlight of Eid celebrations, fostering love and joy.

Important Concepts to Remember

- **Gratitude:** Thanking Allah for the strength to fast and the blessings of Ramadan.
- **Unity:** Reaffirming bonds with family, friends, and the wider Muslim community.
- **Generosity:** Acts of charity and kindness reflect the values cultivated during Ramadan.
- **Joy and Renewal:** A fresh start marked by celebrations and joy.

How to Perform Salat al- Eid

The prayer on Eid day is a little bit different than usual. Here is a breakdown of each step

Before the Prayer

Make Ghusl

- It's recommended to purify yourself and wear your best, clean clothes.

Pay Zakat al-Fitr:

- Ensure your Zakat al-Fitr has been given before the prayer.

Recite the Takbir:

- Begin reciting the Takbir from the night before Eid and on the way to the prayer venue:
- "Allahu Akbar, Allahu Akbar, La ilaha illallah, Allahu Akbar, Allahu Akbar wa lillahil-hamd."

During the Prayer

First Rak'ah:

- The imam starts with the opening takbir (Allahu Akbar).
- You follow by saying "Allahu Akbar" with the imam.
- There are 6 or 7 additional takbirs in this rak'ah.
 - Raise your hands and say "Allahu Akbar" with each takbir.
 - Pause briefly after each takbir with hands at your sides.
- After the takbirs, the imam recites Surah Al-Fatihah and another surah (commonly Surah Al-A'la).
- Continue the rak'ah as usual (ruku', sujood, etc.).

Second Rak'ah:

- Stand up for the second rak'ah. The imam
- begins with 5 additional takbirs.
 - Again, raise your hands and say "Allahu Akbar" with each takbir.
 - Pause briefly between takbirs.
- The imam recites Surah Al-Fatihah and another surah (commonly Surah Al-Ghashiyah).
- Complete the rak'ah with ruku', sujood, and finish the prayer with the tasleem (saying "Assalamu Alaikum wa Rahmatullah" on both sides).

Ramadan observation across cultures

Ramadan is observed worldwide by Muslims, but cultural practices, foods, and traditions vary by region. While the core elements of fasting, prayer, and charity remain consistent, the ways communities celebrate the month reflect their unique cultural identities.

Middle East and North Africa

Food & Iftar:

- Common dishes: Dates, lentil soup, samosas, and kabsa (rice and meat dish). Egypt:
- Lanterns (fanoos) are hung in homes and streets as symbols of Ramadan joy.
- Morocco: Harira (a hearty soup) is a staple for breaking the fast, accompanied by chebakia (sweet sesame cookies).

Traditions:

- Drummers (mesaharati) roam neighborhoods before dawn to wake people for Suhoor. Family gatherings are central, with emphasis on charity to the less fortunate.

South Asia (Pakistan, Bangladesh, India)

Food & Iftar:

- Dishes: Samosas, pakoras (fried snacks), biryani, and jalebi (syrupy sweets).
- Rooh Afza (a rose-flavored drink) is a popular beverage to break the fast.

Traditions:

- Mosques are packed for Taraweeh prayers, with Quran recitations often led by renowned scholars. Neighborhoods light up with special markets selling Ramadan delicacies and Eid clothing.

Western Countries (USA, UK, Canada, Australia)

Food & Iftar:

- Multicultural dishes reflect the diversity of Muslim communities.
- Dates and water remain staples for breaking the fast.

Traditions:

- Mosques organize interfaith iftar events to educate non-Muslims about Ramadan.
- Schools and workplaces accommodate fasting Muslims with adjusted schedules.

Ramadan observation across cultures

Levant (Jordan, Palestine, Syria, Lebanon) Food & Iftar:

- Dishes: Fattoush, hummus, and maqluba (layered rice and meat dish).
- Dessert: Qatayef (sweet stuffed pancakes).

Traditions:

- Family meals emphasize hospitality, with open invitations to guests.
- Nightly Quran recitations and long Taraweeh prayers are common.

East Asia (China, Japan, Korea)

Food & Iftar:

- Hui Muslims in China break their fast with traditional lamb dishes and rice.
- Japan: Muslim communities often share meals of curries and sushi.

Traditions:

- Islamic centers play a crucial role in organizing Ramadan activities.
- Small yet tight-knit Muslim communities come together for iftar and prayers.

Sub-Saharan Africa

Food & Iftar:

- Common dishes: Jollof rice, stews, fried plantains, and dates.
- Somalia: Spiced tea and sambusa (meat-filled pastries) are favorites.

Traditions:

- Community iftars are widespread, with a focus on feeding the needy.
- Mosques organize Quranic recitation contests for children.

Common Themes Across Cultures:

- **Charity:** Feeding the poor and performing acts of kindness are central.
- **Community:** Shared meals, prayers, and events strengthen bonds.
- **Devotion:** Increased prayers, Quran recitation, and acts of worship are universal.



How to Make the Most out of Ramadan

Some final tips and tricks to make your Ramadan smoother and more productive:

01

Hack your Suhoor

Set Two Alarms:

- One to wake up and one to remind you to stop eating—avoid last-minute sips! The time can quickly slip away in the morning.

Go for Energy Bombs:

- Opt for foods with slow-releasing energy like oatmeal, eggs, or Greek yogurt.

02

Optimize your high energy time

Power Hour Post-Fajr:

- Use the early morning energy boost to pray, read Quran, or knock out work tasks.

The 10-Minute Rule:

- Feeling sluggish? Dedicate 10 minutes to a task before deciding to continue or rest.

03

Add opportunities for bite size spiritual moments

Quran Wherever You Go

- Use audio recitations or apps while commuting, cooking, or resting.

Dua Jar:

- Write duas on slips of paper, put them in a jar, and pull one out each day to focus on.

Mini Challenges:

- Set personal goals, like reading one new Surah, giving daily Sadaqah, or learning a new dua.

04

Social Media Detox

Unplug and redirect your focus:

- Replace scrolling with Quran recitation or an uplifting Islamic podcast.

Set a Timer:

- Allow yourself limited time online—then put the phone down! It's tempting to just scroll when your energy is low, but take this opportunity to persevere and deepen your connection with Islam and Allah (SWT)

Sources/Additional Reading

Quran.com

Access the Quran in English and information about the Quran

Ramadan | Fasting, Traditions, & Facts

Britannica article covering many facts about Ramadan

The Significance of Ramadan

A detailed explainer of Ramadan and fasting in other religions

What Islam says about...Ramadan

FAQ from the Yaqeen Institute about Ramadan with infographics and videos

